But Louis had not been sympathetic to his brother's ambitions. Perhaps he simply thought that the open-minded al-Mustansir was a likely convert to Christianity.[2]

Whatever the motivation, enthusiasm for the project among the French knights was nonexistent. "If we take not the cross, we shall lose the King's favour," one of them remarked, in the hearing of Jean de Joinville, "and if we take the cross, we shall lose the favour of God, since we take not the cross for Him, but for fear of the King." James of Aragon refused to have anything to do with the war against his allies, and Joinville himself decided not to accompany his king: "They all did mortal sin that counselled his going," he wrote, "because . . . all the realm was at good peace with itself and with all its neighbors . . . after he had gone, the state of the realm [did nothing but] worsen."[3]

Louis finally managed to raise a certain amount of support. The king of Navarre, Theobald, had married Louis's daughter Isabella in 1255; he now agreed to accompany his father-in-law. Prince Edward of England had also promised to join the army in North Africa, but had not yet embarked. Along with his three older sons, Louis landed in Carthage on July 18 and marched his army the fifteen miles towards Tunis. He began to besiege the city, but within weeks was suffering from what Joinville calls "a flux of the belly." Dysentery ravaged the attackers; the Florentine chronicler Giovanni Villani tells us that Louis's second son John died, along with "an innumerable company of the common folk."[4]

On August 25, after two weeks of suffering, the king of France died in camp. Charles of Anjou and Edward of England both arrived not long after to find Philip, the king's oldest son and heir, also ill with dysentery. The conquest of Tunis had never been likely; now Charles negotiated a peace with al-Mustansir, who paid him off in order to get rid of the besieging army, and the demoralized Crusaders returned home. King Theobald of Navarre stopped in Sicily, where he too grew ill and died. This left the throne of Navarre in the hands of his younger brother Henry, who was by all accounts a competent ruler, although so corpulent that he was nicknamed "Henry the Fat" by his contemporaries. (Four years later, Henry the Fat suffocated on his own adipose tissue, leaving his infant daughter Joan as queen of Navarre.)

Philip recovered; he took the coffins of his father and brother back to France and began his rule as Philip III.

Edward of England was unwilling to abandon his crusade. He collected his own men and a few extras (among them, a Milanese priest named Tebaldo Visconti who had been invited to join the journey to Egypt by Louis IX himself) and sailed towards the Holy Land.